

Zachary Lim

PhD Candidate in Education

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Research Interests

Sociology of science, philosophy of science, philosophy of language, conceptual ethics and engineering, history of science, political epistemology, social science methodology, computational linguistics, computer-assisted text analysis

Education

PhD	Harvard University , Education Focus on social science methodology, computer-assisted text analysis, and the history of methodology. - Committee: Sebastian Muñoz-Najar Galvez, Luke W. Miratrix, Catherine Snow - Relevant Coursework: Conceptual Engineering, Epistemic Injustice, Ethnographic Fieldwork, The Past and Futures of the University, Dewey's Philosophy of Education, Research Methods and Practices in the History of Science, Historiography of the History of Science, Anscombe's Intention, Carnap and Quine, Intermediate and Advanced Statistical Methods for Applied Educational Research, Rawls and Liberal Political Theory, The Value of Truth and Knowledge in Democracies, Agnotology: The History of Knowledge and Ignorance, Art and Understanding, Philosophy of Education	Cambridge, MA Sept 2019 – May 2026
	Princeton University , Ivy Plus Exchange Scholar Advisor: Brandon Stewart	Princeton, NJ Sept 2023 – Dec 2023
BA	University of Washington , summa cum laude, Linguistics (Honors) and Japanese (Honors); Interdisciplinary Honors - Linguistics Honors Thesis: An "Intentional" Challenge of the Concept of Competence — Critiqued assumptions of generative linguistics and proposed a pragmatics-based formal model of natural language. - Japanese Honors Thesis: Applying the Natural Semantic Metalanguage Framework to Foreign Language Instruction — Modified a decompositional semantics framework and conducted a pilot study on foreign language instruction.	Seattle, WA Sept 2012 – June 2015
	Osaka University , Exchange Program	Osaka, Japan Mar 2014 – Aug 2014

Conference Presentations

LIPE: Latent Interview Protocols Engineer Peer-reviewed conference paper Annual Meeting of the American Educational Research Association (AERA) Los Angeles, CA	Apr 2026
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Working Papers

LIPE: Latent Interview Protocols Engineer

Introduces a method and software tool for recovering latent interview protocols from interview corpora by clustering interviewer utterances into protocol questions using semantic embeddings, and modeling typical question sequences as directed graphs. The approach enables researchers to reverse-engineer semi-structured interview designs and retrieve responses by inferred question type.

- [Python package](#)
- Conference paper (AERA 2026, accepted)

A Genealogy of Philosophical Framing in Methodological Disputes

Presents a genealogical analysis of how philosophical framing entered and evolved within qualitative–quantitative methodological debates. The paper traces how different actors mobilized philosophical concepts in distinct ways across historical moments, and analyzes these uses through the lens of social-epistemic theories, including echo chambers and willful ignorance, to understand how methodological disagreements persist and stabilize.

HIPR: Hierarchical Propositions for Computer-Assisted Text Analysis

Introduces a method and software tool for recovering propositions from text using a semantically rich formal model. The paper proposes hierarchical propositions as a representation that captures a broader range of semantic content than prior approaches while enabling entailment relations between propositions. This structure allows propositions and proposition counts to function as analytic features, extending beyond word-based representations and enabling more sophisticated search and exploration of large text corpora.

- [Python package](#)

Computer-Assisted Text Analysis: History and a General Framework

Examines the historical development of computer-assisted text analysis methods across multiple fields and proposes a general framework for conducting such analyses. The framework is informed by established approaches to qualitative text analysis and aims to clarify the role of the researcher at each stage of analysis, specifying how computational tools can assist interpretive work. The paper argues that this approach can help establish computer-assisted text analysis as a robust methodological tradition in the social sciences, rather than as a hybrid or compromise between qualitative and quantitative methods.

The Epistemic Goals of Research

Argues that persistent methodological disputes are partly driven by the absence of a shared account of the epistemic goals of research. The paper critiques traditional conceptions of truth as a research goal while also rejecting arbitrariness because that would undermine the possibility of epistemic authority. It seeks to articulate an intermediate account of epistemic goals that can serve as a common reference point for evaluating and adjudicating methodological disagreements across research traditions.

Research Collaborations

Higher Education in the 21st Century, Research Assistant

Applied computer-assisted text analysis to previously qualitative data.

- Built text classifiers using pretrained embeddings and neural networks.
- Used LLM few-shot classification methods.
- Advised on augmenting qualitative analyses with computational techniques.

Project Zero, Harvard

Oct 2024 – Sept 2025

Teaching and Pedagogy

Harvard Graduate School of Education, Instructor

Cambridge, MA

Course: Evidence

2021 – 2025

- Served as Teaching Fellow (August 2021), then Instructor (Summer 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025)
- Designed classes introducing types of evidence in education research.
- Led class of ~70 students and supervised teaching fellows.

Harvard College, Teaching Fellow

Cambridge, MA

Course: Ignorance, Lies, Hogwash, and Humbug

Jan 2023 – May 2024

- Spring 2023, Spring 2024

Harvard Graduate School of Education, Teaching Fellow

Cambridge, MA

Course: Intermediate and Advanced Statistical Methods for Applied Educational Research

Jan 2024 – May 2024

Harvard Medical School, Pedagogy Fellow

Boston, MA

Scientific Citizenship Initiative

Sept 2021 – May 2022

- Designed and programmed ethics simulations (HTML, CSS, JavaScript).
- Created lesson plans and instructional materials for teachers.
- Participated in ethics pedagogy discussions with Safra Center fellows.

Harvard Graduate School of Arts and Sciences, Instructor

Cambridge, MA

Course: Philosophy and Research: An Introduction to Applied Philosophy

Jan 2022

- Designed syllabus from scratch.
- Taught a 10-session intensive mini-course on philosophy and research.

Harvard Graduate School of Education, Teaching Fellow

Cambridge, MA

Course: Ethical Questions in Higher Education

Sept 2021

Harvard School of Public Health, Teaching Fellow

Boston, MA

Course: Ethical Basis of the Practice of Public Health

June 2020 – Aug 2021

- Summer 2020, Summer 2021

Harvard Graduate School of Arts and Sciences, Instructor

Cambridge, MA

Course: Why Trust Research?

Jan 2021

- Designed syllabus from scratch.
- Taught two sections meeting three times per week over two weeks.

Harvard Graduate School of Education, Teaching Fellow

Cambridge, MA

Course: Art and Understanding

Sept 2020 – Dec 2020

- Led weekly sections on philosophy of art and epistemology.
- Supported students on written work.

Presentations

Conceptions of Reality and Truth in Qualitative Research Methodologies

Apr 2020

Student Research Symposium, Harvard Graduate School of Education

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The History and Impact of Conceptions of Truth in the Social Sciences

Feb 2020

PhD on Tap, Harvard Graduate School of Arts and Sciences Student Center

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Challenging the Concept of Competence

May 2015

Undergraduate Research Symposium, University of Washington

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Workshops

Navigating Research Boundaries: Disciplines, Methodologies, Environments, Identities

A summer school workshop for early-career researchers on navigating research boundaries across disciplines, methodologies, environments, and identities

University of Groningen

May 2021 – May 2021

Service

LGBTQ@GSAS, President

- Expanded programming from 1–2 events/month to 5–6 events/month.
- Built and trained a leadership team.
- Established partnerships across Harvard.

Harvard Graduate School of

Arts and Sciences

June 2024 – present

Office of Equity, Diversity, Inclusion & Belonging, GSAS, LGBTQ+-Focused Diversity and Inclusion Fellow

- Compiled and shared best practices for affinity groups.
- Supported LGBTQ+ programming across GSAS.

Harvard Graduate School of

Arts and Sciences

June 2024 – June 2025

Figure Skating@GSAS, Founder and President

- Organize introductory workshops and community skating sessions 2–3 times a year.
- Support figure skaters with services like group sharpening and coaching.

Harvard Graduate School of

Arts and Sciences

May 2022 – June 2025

Harvard GSAS Student Council (GSC), Advisor to the Council

- Meet regularly with current GSC officers and chairs to provide historical context and support.

Cambridge, MA

June 2023 – Sept 2024

Harvard GSAS Student Council (GSC), President

- Restructured GSC by doubling student leaders, oversaw \$150,000 budget, and increased leader retention by 4x.
- Represented graduate students at senior leadership meetings and secured new seats on strategic committees.
- Organized monthly open meetings with the GSAS community and conducted surveys to represent students' interests.

Cambridge, MA

June 2022 – May 2023

Harvard GSAS Student Council (GSC), Vice President

- Oversaw GSC grant applications, awards, and major meetings with monthly newsletters.
- Reorganized data systems to reduce human error in managing over 85 program representatives.
- Organized the 2021 and 2022 January@GSAS Mini-Courses program where PhD students taught courses.

Cambridge, MA

June 2021 – May 2022

Harvard GSAS Student Council (GSC), Secretary

- Oversaw GSC grant applications, awards, and organized major meetings with monthly newsletters.
- Reorganized data systems to reduce human error in managing over 85 program representatives.
- Organized the 2021 January@GSAS Mini-Courses program.

Cambridge, MA

July 2020 – May 2021

Harvard GSAS Student Center, Intellectual and Cultural Fellow

- Organized interdisciplinary lightning talks, student-faculty dinners, and cultural events.
- Coordinated Asian American and Pacific Islander Heritage Month programs.

Cambridge, MA

Aug 2022 – May 2023

Harvard GSAS Student Center, Public Service Fellow

- Organized public service-related events.
- Partnered with Harvard offices and local organizations to provide new volunteer opportunities.

Cambridge, MA

Aug 2021 – May 2022

Harvard Graduate School of Education, Advisor

- Advised Ed.M. students on registration, available resources, and PhD program applications.

Cambridge, MA
July 2020 – May 2023

Harvard Graduate Residence Hall Council (GRHC), President

- Led organizational restructuring meetings and oversaw \$50,000 annual budget for events and residence hall improvements.
- Conducted first exhaustive survey of 400 residents in over a decade, using data analysis to draw important conclusions.
- Advocated for measures to ensure residents' safety during the Covid-19 pandemic.

Cambridge, MA
Aug 2021 – June 2022

Harvard Graduate Residence Hall Council (GRHC), Treasurer

- Managed budget for events and residence hall improvements.
- Reorganized financial documents and procedures to increase accountability and transparency.
- Led meetings to revise GRHC roles and responsibilities.

Cambridge, MA
July 2020 – Aug 2021

Work Experience

Cambridge YMCA, Tai Chi Instructor

- Teach Yang-style Tai Chi group classes for adults of all levels.

Cambridge, MA
May 2024 – present

Education for Development Foundation America, Executive Director

- Collaborated with international offices on fundraising and outreach.
- Developed full-stack website for fundraising and administrative automation.
- Pushed for organizational reforms to improve efficiency and quality.

Mercer Island, WA
July 2019 – Feb 2021

Sushi Jiro @ Keppel Bay, Operations Manager

- Mediated communication between local and Japanese staff.
- Built inventory and front-end operational systems.
- Hired, trained, and managed floor staff.

Singapore
Nov 2018 – Mar 2019

Online Instruction (Private), Computer Science Instructor

- Taught adult students in Japanese via Skype.
- Designed individualized lessons aligned with learner goals.

Remote / Japan
Sept 2017 – July 2019

Singapore Armed Forces Medical Training Institution, Corporal First Class (Conscription)

- Supported curriculum digitization and transformation.
- Built a full-stack 360-degree feedback platform.
- Automated administrative systems including exams, rosters, and schedules.

Singapore
Aug 2015 – Aug 2017

Skills

Programming Languages: Python, R, C#, Haskell, VBA

Technical Skills: Text analysis, full-stack web development, computer-assisted text analysis

Natural Languages: Japanese (proficient), Mandarin (proficient)